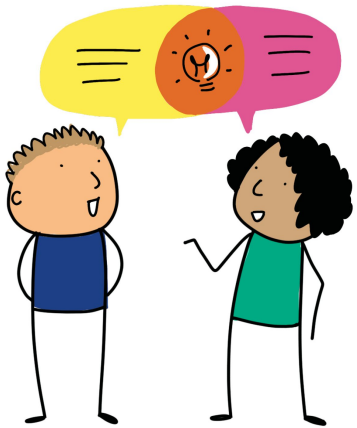
Liberating Structures: Discovery & Action Dialogue

A collection of practical tips, tweaks, and resources



Introduction

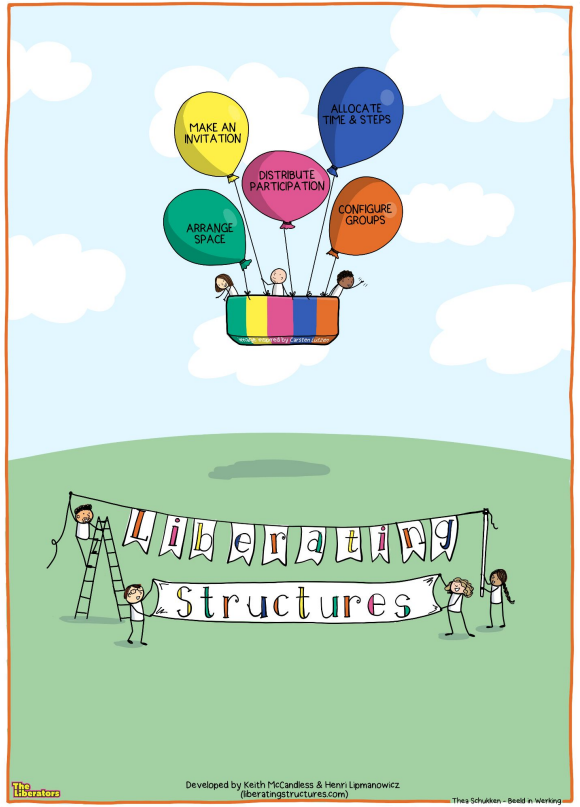
For almost a decade, Liberating Structures have been an important part of my facilitation toolkit. Over the years, I've created my own materials, enjoyed using those created by others, picked up countless practical tips, and discovered many useful tweaks.

Until now, all of these were scattered across different places, often leaving me searching for that one illustration, idea, or tip when I needed it most. So I decided to bring everything together in one place, with a separate guide for each Liberating Structure. And yes, it definitely satisfies my inner facilitation nerd. 🤓

I'm creating these guides mostly for myself, and they'll probably never be finished. I keep learning, experimenting, and discovering new things. But since sharing freely with the community is an important part of what we do, I'll also make them available through [our public GitHub repository](#).

I hope you'll find something useful in them too. Enjoy!

[Barry Overeem](#)



Liberating Structures were developed by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. The foundational Liberating Structures materials are shared under a Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 license (CC BY-SA 4.0).

These Practice Guides build on their work and combine it with our own experiences, illustrations, and practical tips.

The Liberators

About Discovery & Action Dialogue



Discovery and Action Dialogue (DAD) helps groups discover successful practices that already exist but often go unnoticed. In about 30–90 minutes, participants explore a shared challenge, learn from each other's experiences, and identify practical actions they can take.

DAD builds on the concept of *Positive Deviance*: even when people face similar challenges and have access to the same resources, some find unusual but effective ways to succeed. Rather than bringing in outside experts or introducing new solutions, DAD helps groups uncover what is already working within their own community or organization.

The process is structured around seven questions that guide participants through a collective *Treasure Hunt*. In small groups of 5–7 people, a host asks the questions and keeps the conversation on track without answering them. A scribe captures insights and may actively participate. Together, participants identify successful practices, explore what makes them effective, and consider how others might apply them.

What makes DAD powerful is its focus on discovering solutions from within. Instead of assuming that change requires new ideas or external expertise, it recognizes that people closest to a challenge often already have valuable knowledge and experience. By making these practices visible and encouraging others to experiment with them, DAD helps groups turn local discoveries into meaningful change.

The Liberators

Positive Deviance explained



The Liberators

Purposes



- **Solve problems from within.** Empower people closest to a challenge to discover and apply practical solutions in their own environment.
- **Discover hidden knowledge and practices.** Uncover unusual but successful ways of working that people may not even recognize as valuable.
- **Spread successful practices.** Help others learn from and experiment with practices that have already proven effective.
- **Inspire lasting change.** Encourage people to adopt successful practices voluntarily, rather than having solutions imposed from outside.
- **Connect people across boundaries.** Bring together different roles, teams, and levels to learn from each other and solve shared challenges.

Discovery & Action Dialogue enacts Liberating Structures principle #2

Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]



The Liberators

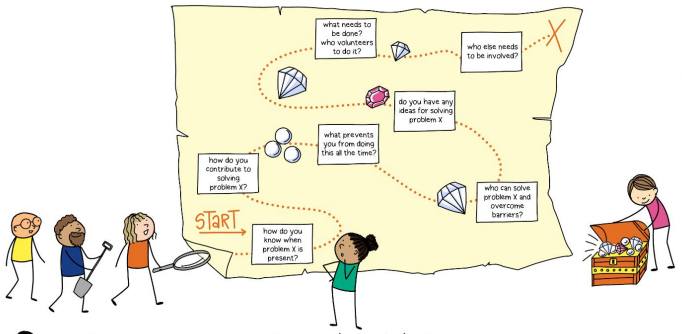
Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]

Discovery and Action Dialogue

Discover, Invent, And Unleash Local Solutions To Chronic Problems

(~30 - 90 min)

We're going to uncover the behaviors and practices some of us are already using to tackle our shared challenge. It's like a treasure hunt for solutions hidden in our midst.



1. Invite participants to explore a shared challenge. Form small groups of 5–7 people.
2. Explain the purpose: discovering successful practices that already exist but often go unnoticed. Introduce the process. Each group selects a host and a scribe. (3 min.)
3. Launch the Treasure Hunt! Explore the seven questions together, one at a time. The host asks the questions and keeps the group on track without answering them. The scribe captures insights and may participate in the discussion. Allow equal time for each question. (15–60 min.)
4. Return to the whole group. Each scribe shares key discoveries, successful practices, and next steps. (5 min.)
5. Discuss who else should be invited to the next dialogue. (3 min.)

Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz (liberatingstructures.com)

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

Illustration we created with [Thea Schukken]

Discovery and Action Dialogue

7 Questions and Purposes

(~30 - 90 min)

	Questions:	Purposes:
1	How do you know when problem X is present?	Affirm participants' knowledge of the problem and invite questions.
2	How do you contribute to solving problem X?	Focus on personal practices, NOT what other people do or don't do.
3	What prevents you from doing this all the time?	Identify barriers and constraints to the effective behavior by asking "What prevents you?" rather than "Why don't you?"
4	Who can solve problem X and overcome barriers?	Identify successful strategies; getting around barriers is possible. Spark curiosity and inventiveness.
5	Do you have any ideas for solving problem X?	Identify supports that make the desired behavior more likely. Provide an opportunity to generate and share new ideas.
6	What needs to be done? Who volunteers to do it?	Identify action steps, target dates, and feedback loops for evaluation. Invite volunteers to take each action step.
7	Who else needs to be involved?	Involve more people in discovering and inventing solutions.

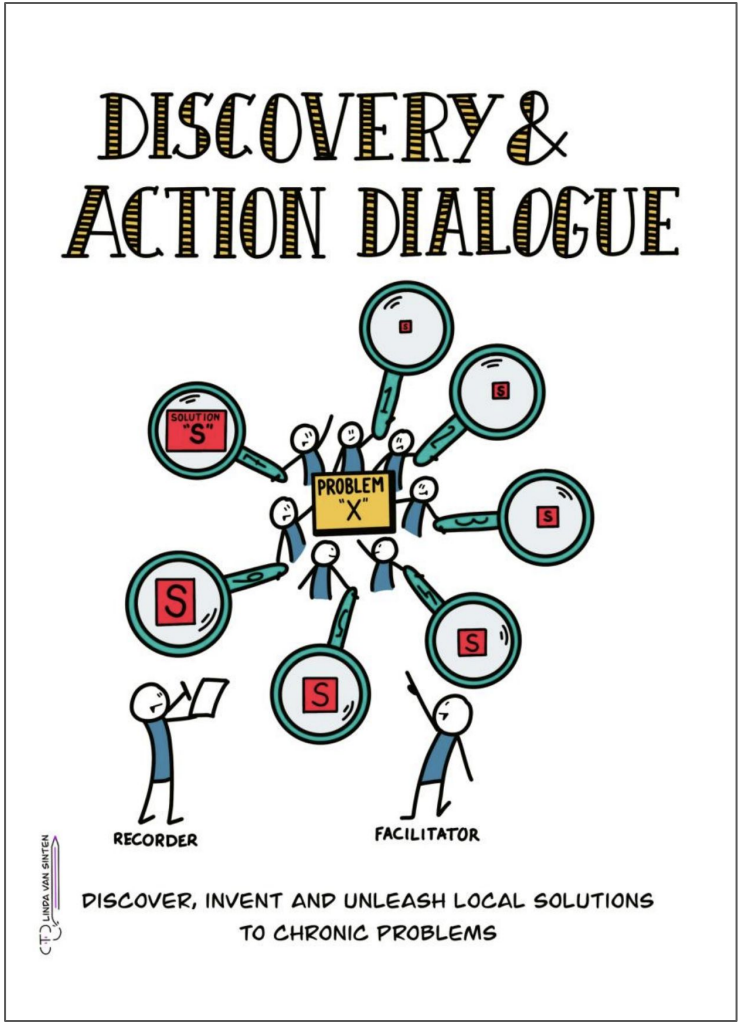


The Liberators

Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz
(liberatingstructures.com)

Thea Schukken - Beeld in Werking

Illustration by
[Linda van Sinten]



The Liberators

Tips & tweaks

Getting started

- **Start with a shared, persistent challenge.** DAD works best when participants face a problem they all recognize. Make it specific enough to explore real experiences, rather than discussing a broad or abstract topic.
- **Let participants identify the challenge.** Use 1-2-4-All or Impromptu Networking beforehand to discover which recurring problem deserves attention.
- **Keep groups small.** Aim for 5–6 participants per group. Smaller groups give everyone more opportunities to contribute and make it easier to explore the questions in depth.
- **Clarify the two roles.** The host (or Guide) asks questions, keeps the conversation focused, and avoids answering. The scribe (or Butterfly Catcher) captures discoveries and can actively participate.
- **Adapt the questions to your challenge.** Translate the seven questions into language participants recognize, while preserving their original purpose. For example, replace "problem X" with "unproductive meetings."

Tips & tweaks

Setting the stage

- **Hold DAD where people work.** Organize the dialogue in participants' everyday work environment to minimize obstacles to participation.
- **Invite people to join spontaneously.** Make informal invitations as you enter the work area. Not everyone needs to be recruited or registered in advance.
- **Create an informal atmosphere.** Arrange chairs in a circle, preferably without tables. Start with brief introductions and an anecdote if appropriate.
- **Use a talking object.** Invite participants to pass an object around the circle. Only the person holding it speaks and chooses who goes next. This can help balance participation.

Tips & tweaks

Running the exercise

- **Talk less, listen more.** Demonstrate genuine curiosity, resist the temptation to advise or fill every pause, and avoid answering the questions yourself. Let participants do most of the talking.
- **Suspend your judgments.** Notice when you form opinions about what is right or wrong. Avoid statements like "That's a good idea" and leave space for participants to make their own judgments.
- **Appreciate candid feedback.** Acknowledge honest contributions, especially when people share difficult experiences or challenge existing assumptions.
- **Focus on what people actually do.** When someone describes a successful approach, ask for a concrete example. What did they do differently? What made it work?
- **Look for positive exceptions.** When participants describe barriers or say something never works, ask whether they can remember a time when it did. Explore how people have found ways around obstacles.

Tips & tweaks

Questions & experiments

- **Keep the questions in sequence.** The seven questions provide a progression from understanding the problem to taking action. Allow flexibility in the time spent on each question rather than changing their order.
- **Explore both sides of question 2.** Consider how people address the challenge for themselves and how they help others. For example: "What do you do to keep your students engaged, and what do you do to keep yourself energized?"
- **Try a shorter version.** For a quick team conversation, use a 15–20-minute DAD. For persistent or complex challenges, allow more time to explore the questions thoroughly.
- **Try DAD in pairs.** Use the seven questions to guide a one-on-one conversation. This can be useful for coaching or exploring a challenge before bringing a larger group together.
- **Experiment with TRIZ-inspired questions.** Replace the first three questions with: (1) What could make this problem much worse? (2) Are we already doing anything that contributes to it? (3) What prevents us from stopping these practices?

Tips & tweaks

Follow-up

- **Capture discoveries, not just ideas.** Ask the scribe to record specific behaviors, successful practices, useful quotes, volunteers, and next steps. These are more valuable than a long list of general suggestions.
- **Make time for the debrief.** Don't rush the final reflection. Give participants enough time to share discoveries, recognize patterns, and identify opportunities for action.
- **Don't assign actions.** Invite people to volunteer for experiments and next steps rather than assigning responsibilities. Ownership should emerge from participants themselves.
- **End with ownership and follow-up.** Identify who is willing to try something, what they will do, and who else should be involved. Revisit the discoveries later to learn what happened.
- **Invite feedback for the host.** Hosting DAD takes practice, so don't judge yourself too harshly. Ask the scribe for direct feedback, particularly about listening, asking questions, and allowing participants to lead.

Combo's

- **Simple Ethnography.** Observe people in their everyday work to better understand their challenges and discover practices worth exploring through DAD.
- **What, So What, Now What?** Reflect on the discoveries, explore what they mean, and decide what to do next.
- **Improv Prototyping.** Turn insights and barriers discovered during DAD into short scenes. Experiment with different behaviors and possible solutions.
- **15% Solutions.** Help participants identify small actions they can take immediately, without needing additional resources or permission.
- **Shift & Share.** Invite different DAD groups to share their discoveries, allowing others to learn from successful practices across teams or departments.
- **Social Network Webbing.** Identify people who can help spread successful practices and build connections to support further action.

When to use it?

- **Overcome persistent impediments.** Help teams discover practical ways to address problems that keep coming back, even after several attempts to solve them.
- **Improve collaboration across teams.** Explore how people successfully handle dependencies, communication gaps, or conflicting priorities.
- **Solve technical challenges.** Uncover creative workarounds and successful practices that colleagues have developed to overcome technical obstacles.
- **Improve stakeholder engagement.** Discover how some teams successfully involve stakeholders who are difficult to reach or engage.
- **Spread successful ways of working.** Bring people from different teams together to discover effective local practices and explore how others could apply them.

Lyse Edwards example

DAD becomes more practical when you tailor the seven questions to a specific challenge.

Example challenge by Lyse Edwards:
How can we make our meetings more productive and worthwhile?

1. **Recognize the problem.** How do you recognize a meeting that wastes time or achieves little?
2. **Discover existing practices.** What do you already do to make meetings productive and worthwhile?
3. **Identify barriers.** What prevents you from doing these things more consistently?
4. **Find positive exceptions.** Who manages to make meetings productive, even when facing the same challenges? What do they do differently?
5. **Generate ideas.** What could help us make our meetings more productive, building on what already works?
6. **Take action.** What could we start doing differently right away? Who is willing to give it a try?
7. **Involve others.** Who else could help us make these changes happen?

Online tips

- **Give each group its own shared document.** Include the seven DAD questions and space for the scribe to capture discoveries, barriers, and possible actions. Keep the questions visible so everyone can follow the conversation.
- **Keep the host out of the note-taking role.** Online, managing the conversation and capturing insights simultaneously is particularly demanding. Assign a separate scribe who can also participate in the discussion.
- **Help groups manage their time.** Encourage hosts to keep an eye on the clock and move through all seven questions. Send a broadcast message to breakout rooms when it's time to start wrapping up.
- **Make successful practices visible across groups.** Have scribes add their discoveries to a shared board before returning to the main room. Participants can then compare practices rather than listen to lengthy reports.
- **Keep the same groups for follow-up dialogues.** When exploring a persistent challenge over multiple sessions, maintaining group continuity can help participants revisit earlier discoveries and report what they tried.

“Discovery & Action Dialogue” in action





The Liberators

“Discovery & Action Dialogue”
in action



“Discovery & Action Dialogue”
in action



Interested in learning more?

Articles about Discovery & Action Dialogue:

- Our thoughts on this Liberating Structure
- The official description of Discovery & Action Dialogue

Looking for (even) more inspiration?

- Check the resources on the Liberating Structures website
- Check our blog with 100+ articles
- Download the LiSA app by Holisticon
- Browse our public GitHub repository with illustrations, DIY workshops, templates, papers, and other free resources.
- Here's the webshop with Linda van Sinten's illustrations
- Join our public online or in-person meetups

Interested in collaborating?

- Check my workshop offerings.
- I'm available as a trainer or facilitator for meetings, workshops, and other gatherings.
- Whether you want to learn Liberating Structures or use them to tackle a real challenge, I'd be happy to help.

Get in touch: barry.overeem@theliberators.com



The Liberators


The Liberators
Unleashing Organisational Superpowers